

In the Grandmother's Hut

Every morning, Peter returned with his goats. Heidi eagerly joined them as they headed to the pasture. Heidi found herself growing stronger and getting a sun-kissed tan as the days passed.

When autumn arrived, the mountain air became crisp and windy. Sometimes, Grandfather would look out at the fierce wind and say, "You need to stay inside today, Heidi. The wind might sweep you down into the valley with just one big puff!"

On those windy days, Peter felt sad without Heidi. He missed her company. Without her, the goats hardly followed him. Also, he missed out on the yummy big lunches he enjoyed when Heidi was around.

On days when she stayed home, Heidi didn't mind at all. She loved to watch her grandfather working with his tools, sawing and hammering away. One of her favorite activities was watching him make small, round cheeses and churn butter with his strong arms. And when the wind roared through



the fir trees, Heidi would run outside. The magical sounds of the branches swaying thrilled her.

As it got colder, Heidi had to wear her shoes, stockings, and a warm dress to keep cozy. Peter would blow into his hands to warm them as he arrived each morning. He shivered in the chilly air. Eventually, it became too snowy even for Peter to visit. One morning, Heidi watched from the window as snow kept piling up, higher and higher. After a time, it nearly covered their windows completely.

The snowfall continued for several days. Heidi wondered if it would bury their little cottage. Finally, the snow stopped. Grandfather had to shovel away the heaps of snow from their doorstep and around the windows. Later that day, Heidi and her grandfather sat near the cozy fireplace. They felt safe and warm inside their snug mountain home.

When Heidi was by the fire, noisy footsteps sounded outside. Then the door burst open. It was Peter, coming to visit Heidi. He mumbled a "Good-evening" and walked up to the fire. His face was all bright. Heidi laughed because his clothes were dripping water everywhere. He was melting like a snowman in the warm room.

Grandfather asked Peter how school was going. Heidi, curious as always, bombarded Peter with lots of questions. Peter wasn't much of a talker, so he found it hard to keep up with Heidi's rapid questions. But at least it gave him time to dry off.

While they talked, Grandfather was watching with a twinkle in his eye. Finally, he joked with Peter, "You've been



under fire, General. Now it's time to refuel!" And with that, Grandfather made a hearty supper. Peter ate hungrily.

As it grew dark, Peter knew it was time to go. But before he left, he told Heidi, "I'll be back next Sunday. My grandmother says she would love to meet you."

Heidi was excited about this. She told Grandfather that they needed to visit Grandmother first thing the next morning. Four days later, when the sun was shining and the snow was crackling, Heidi pleaded with Grandfather to let her go visit Grandmother.

Grandfather agreed, fetched her warm cover, and led her outside. Everything was silent. The snow-covered trees sparkled in the sunlight. They looked as if they were sprinkled with silver and gold. Heidi ran around shouting, "Grandfather, come quick! Look at the trees!"

Grandfather came out with a big sled, wrapped Heidi warmly, and set her on it. Holding Heidi securely, she and Grandfather shot through the magical winter landscape. Heidi shouted with excitement. She felt like she was flying!

Grandfather stopped the sled in front of Peter's hut. "Go on in," he told Heidi. "When it gets dark, start on your way home." After unwrapping her from her warm coverings, Grandfather left with the sled.

Heidi opened the door to a small, dark kitchen. She walked into a narrow room where Peter's mother was sewing his coat. Heidi recognized it right away. In the corner of the room, there was an old woman. This was Peter's grandmother. Heidi walked up to her and cheerfully said, "Hello,



Heidi is delighted by the magical winter landscape



Grandmother! I'm here now, did I make you wait long?"

Peter's grandmother, who was blind, felt around for Heidi's hand. "Are you the little girl who lives with Uncle up on the mountain? Is your name Heidi?"

"Yes," Heidi replied. "Grandfather just brought me down in the sled."

"How is that possible?" Peter's grandmother cried. "Your hands are as warm as toast! Brigida, did Uncle really come down with the child?"

Peter's mom, Brigida, was surprised and unsure if Heidi had come with her grandfather. But Heidi insisted that they had sled down together, wrapped up warmly. This surprised everyone. They hadn't expected Heidi to stay with her grumpy grandfather for long.

Grandmother said, "Brigida, tell me what she looks like."

"She has her mother's long, thin arms and legs. She has black eyes and curly hair like her father. She looks a bit like both of them."

While the women were talking, Heidi had been taking in everything. Then she said, "Grandmother, look at the shutter over there. It's hanging loose. If Grandfather were here, he would fix it. It'll break the windowpane the way it's flapping!"

"What a sweet child you are," said Grandmother tenderly. "I can hear shutters banging, but I can't see it, Child. This cottage rattles and creaks, and when the wind blows, it comes in through every crack. Someday the whole house will crum-



ble and fall on top of us. If only Peter knew how to fix it! We have no one else."

"Grandmother, can't you see the shutter?" asked Heidi.

"Child, I can't see anything," said the old woman sadly.

"Can you see when I open the shutter to let in the light?"

"No, no, not even then. Nobody can ever show me the light again."

Heidi was frightened. "But what about when you go out into the snow, where everything is bright? Come with me, Grandmother, I'll show you!" She took the old woman by the hand and tried to lead her outside.

"Just let me stay here, child," said the old woman. "Everything is dark for me. My poor eyes can't see anything."

"But Grandmother, what about in the summer? You can't see when the sun shines down on the mountains to say good-night?"

"No, child, I can never see the fiery mountains again. I have to live in darkness, always."

Heidi burst out crying now. "Can't anyone make it light for you? Is there nobody who can do it, Grandmother? Nobody?"

Grandmother tried to comfort Heidi. She said, "Heidi, let me tell you something. People who can't see love to listen to friendly words. Sit down beside me and tell me all about yourself. Talk to me about your grandfather. It's been a long time since I have heard anything about him. I used to know him very well."

Wiping her tears, Heidi felt a spark of hope. She prom-



ised to talk to her grandfather about making things better for Grandmother. She thought he could fix the house and maybe help Grandmother see the light.

Full of energy, Heidi began to describe her life with her grandfather. Listening carefully, Peter's mother and grandmother would mutter to each other, "Did you hear that? Do you hear what she says about Uncle?"

As Heidi was telling her story, Peter barged in with a loud thump on the door. He was so happy to see Heidi that his eyes grew huge, and he smiled broadly. Heidi greeted him with a cheerful, "Good evening, Peter!"

Peter's grandmother was surprised that it was already time for him to come home. "Time flies," she said. "How's your reading coming along?"

Peter shrugged and said, "Just the same."

"Oh dear, I was hoping you'd gotten better," sighed his grandmother. "You're nearly twelve years old!"

Heidi, curious, asked, "Why do you want him to read better?" Grandmother explained that there was an old prayer book with lovely songs on a shelf. She had nearly forgotten the songs because no one reads them to her anymore. She hoped Peter could read them to her someday. But she was losing hope that he would ever learn to read well.

It was getting late. Peter's mother lit a lamp. Seeing this, Heidi quickly said her goodbyes. "Good-night. I have to go since it's getting dark."

But Grandmother was worried. "Wait, Child, don't go up alone! Peter, go with her and make sure she's safe and warm.



Heidi describes her life to Grandmother



Does Heidi have a shawl?"

Heidi, already out the door, shouted back, "I don't have one, but I'll be fine." She started running so fast that Peter struggled to keep up.

From the house, Grandmother anxiously called, "Brigida, hurry! Run after her with a warm shawl. It's cold tonight!"

As Heidi and Peter climbed up the path, they met the old man coming down. He was happy Heidi was on time and wrapped her in her cover. He then carried Heidi up the hill in his arms. Brigida arrived just in time to see this and went back to tell Grandmother what she saw. "Thank goodness," the old woman said happily. "I hope she comes back. She makes me feel so much better! She's so kind and talks so nicely." All evening, the old woman kept thinking, "I hope he lets her come back! Now I have something to look forward to, thank God!"

As soon as Heidi and her grandfather were inside their cottage, Heidi was bursting to talk. "Grandfather, we need to take some nails and a hammer to Grandmother's house tomorrow. A shutter is loose, and many other things are falling apart. Everything makes noise in her house."

"Really? And who said we must fix it?" her grandfather asked.

"Nobody told me, but I know," Heidi answered. "Poor Grandmother said she was worried the house might fall apart. Also, Grandfather, she can't see well. Can you help make her house brighter? It must be so scary to be in the dark and have no one to help you! Oh, please, Grandfather,



can you fix it for her? I know you can."

Heidi was holding onto her grandfather and looking up at him with hopeful eyes. Finally, he looked down and said, "Okay, child, we'll make sure the house won't shake anymore. We can do it tomorrow."

Heidi was so happy to hear this that she started dancing around the room, shouting, "We're going to fix it tomorrow! We can do it tomorrow!"

The next day, Grandfather took Heidi down as he had promised. After Heidi had greeted Grandmother, he started checking the house. Grandmother was so happy to see Heidi again. She had been working at a spinning wheel making wool thread. She stopped her work and exclaimed, "Here is the child again! She has come back!"

Heidi grabbed Grandmother's hands. She sat on a stool by her feet, starting to chat. Soon, loud banging noises came from outside. Grandmother got scared, accidentally almost knocking over her spinning wheel. She screamed, "Oh, God!"

"Grandmother, don't be frightened," said the child. She put her arms around the old woman. "Grandfather is just fixing everything for you."

When Brigida went outside, she saw Heidi's grandfather putting a new beam in the wall. She thanked him for his help. Grandmother wanted to thank him too. But Grandfather said gruffly that he didn't need any thanks.

He worked hard all afternoon, even climbing on the roof to fix it. Eventually, he had to stop because he ran out of nails and it was getting dark. Heidi was ready to go home.



Grandfather tucked her snugly in his arms, and they left.

As the winter passed, Grandmother felt happier. Her days were brighter with Heidi's visits. Every morning, Grandmother eagerly waited to hear Heidi's footsteps. When Heidi arrived, she would share stories and make Grandmother smile and laugh.

Before Heidi's arrival in her life, Grandmother used to wish for days to end quickly. But now, with Heidi's visits, she felt joy. She wondered how the time passed so quickly. Even Brigida agreed because Heidi had also won her heart.

Grandmother often hoped that Heidi would stay with them. "And I hope that your grandfather stays as kind as he has become lately."

"Is Heidi doing alright, Brigida?" was a question Grandmother asked often. The answer was always comforting. Heidi grew to love the old woman deeply. Whenever the weather was nice that winter, she visited her every day. When Heidi remembered that Grandmother could not see, she felt very sad. But knowing her visits made the old woman happy brought her some comfort.

Grandfather fixed up the cottage well. He carried down heavy loads of timber to use. Grandmother said that the cottage was no longer noisy. She said she slept better that winter than she had in many years, all thanks to the kindness of Grandfather.



Grandfather works hard all afternoon



Two Visitors

Two winters had passed. Heidi was excited because spring was near. This meant warm, gentle winds and the opportunity to play outdoors. She looked forward to seeing the beautiful flowers covering the pastures. She had become skilled in taking care of the goats. They followed her around everywhere.

Heidi was almost eight years old now, and the village school teacher wanted her to start school. But her grandfather had delayed it. He kept her with him instead.

One bright morning in March, as Heidi played outside, a man dressed in black approached her. Seeing her startled look, he kindly reassured her. He said he loved children and asked her not to be afraid. He wanted to know where her grandfather was. Heidi said he was inside, crafting wooden spoons. She led the man inside.

The visitor was the old village parson. He was a long-time friend of Grandfather. When he saw the parson, Grandfather greeted him warmly. He offered him a place to sit. Taking a seat, the parson said: "It's been a long time, neighbor. I have come today to talk with you about something. I'm

sure you can guess what it is."

Grandfather glanced at Heidi standing nearby. "Heidi, run out to see to the goats," said Grandfather. "And bring them some salt. You can stay until I come get you." Heidi swiftly went out as her grandfather had asked.

With Heidi gone, the parson brought up the topic of school. He said Heidi should have already started the previous year.

"I don't want her to go to school," said the old man.

"What do you want the child to do then?"

"I want her to be free and happy as a bird!"

"But she's not a bird, she's a little girl. It's high time for her to learn something. I've come to tell you that so you can make your plans. She needs to come to school next winter."

"I won't do it!" Grandfather shouted. "What about when there's a storm or it's freezing out? It's a two-hour walk! I won't let her go. The wind even chokes me if I go out in the wrong weather. Did you know Adelheid, her mother? She was very delicate, and would even faint sometimes. What if that happens to Heidi? Nobody can make me let her go. I'll fight it in court!"

"You're right," the parson said kindly. "You shouldn't send her to school from here. Why don't you come down to live in the village again? You're leading a strange life here. How can you even keep the child warm in winter?"

"She's young and strong. I keep a fire going all winter. And I couldn't live in the village. The people there hate me, and I hate them."





The parson visits with Grandfather

“You’re wrong about that, I’m sure! Make your peace with God, and then you’ll see how happy you will be.” The parson stood and held out his hand. “I’ll look for you and Heidi next winter, neighbor. We’ll be happy to see you.”

Grandfather shook his visitor’s hand and said, “Thank you for your kindness, but that will never happen.”

“God be with you,” said the parson, and left him sadly.

The old man was feeling grumpy the rest of that day. When Heidi asked him if she could visit Grandmother, he just said, “Not today.”

The next day, they had just finished eating lunch when someone else came to visit. It was Heidi’s aunt Deta. She looked very fancy. She wore a long dress that cleaned the floor as she walked. Grandfather just stared at her silently. Deta started to thank him and say how healthy Heidi looked. She apologized for leaving her with him for so long. She said that she had found a great opportunity for Heidi in Frankfurt. There was a rich family who needed a friend for their daughter. The daughter couldn’t walk and used a wheelchair. This girl needed someone to play and learn with her. Deta thought Heidi was perfect for the job.

Grandfather seemed uninterested in Deta’s proposal and was ignoring her. Deta got angry and said anyone else would be thankful for such news. She said Heidi was eight and didn’t know anything because the old man hadn’t sent her to school or church. Deta felt it was her job to look after Heidi. She felt strongly that this was a chance of a lifetime. She warned Grandfather to be very careful what he did next.

“Be quiet!” Grandfather thundered with flaming eyes. “Take her and ruin her, but don’t bring her back! I do not want to see her looking all fancy and speaking wicked words the way you do.” With that, he stormed out of the hut.

Heidi looked upset and said, “You made him mad!”

“He won’t stay mad long. Now, where are your things?” Deta asked.

“I’m not going,” Heidi said firmly.

Deta looked surprised. “What?” Then more gently she added, “Listen, I’m taking you to a wonderful place. The most beautiful you’ve ever seen.” As she packed Heidi’s clothes, she said again, “Come on, get your hat. It’s not the best hat, but it’s what we have.”

Heidi still said, “I won’t go.”

“Don’t be stubborn like a goat,” Deta responded. “We have to go like Grandfather said. If we don’t, he’ll be even more upset. You’ll love Frankfurt. If you don’t, we can come back. How does that sound?”

Heidi asked, “Can we come back tonight?”

“Not tonight,” Deta explained, “But soon. We’ll take a train and it’ll be fast.” Deta held Heidi’s bag, and they started walking down the mountain.

They met Peter. He had skipped school to gather sticks, which he felt was more useful. He had a big bundle of them. Seeing Heidi and Deta, he asked, “Where are you going?”

Heidi said, “To Frankfurt with Aunt Deta. But I must see Grandmother first. She’s probably waiting for me.”

“It’s too late now,” Deta said quickly, pulling Heidi. She

worried Grandmother might make them stay.

Peter ran to tell Grandmother. He went into her house and slammed his bundle down. Grandmother got scared and asked what was happening. Peter said sadly, “They’ve taken Heidi away.”

“She’s gone?” the worried old woman asked. Brigida had seen Deta walking up the path a little while before. The two soon guessed what had happened. The old woman was shaking. She opened a window and called out as loudly as she could, “Deta! Deta, please don’t take the child away! Don’t take her from us!”

When Heidi heard this, she tried to break free, saying, “I have to go to Grandmother. She’s calling me.”

But Deta wouldn’t let her go. She hurried Heidi along by promising she could come back soon. She said Heidi could even bring a nice gift for Grandmother when she returned.

Heidi liked the idea of bringing a gift and followed Deta without arguing. After a bit, Heidi asked, “What should I bring to Grandmother?”

“You could bring her some soft white rolls, Heidi. The black bread is too hard for poor Grandmother to eat.”

“Yes, I know. She always gives it to Peter,” Heidi agreed. “We have to hurry now. If we get to Frankfurt today, I can come back tomorrow with the rolls.”

Heidi started to run, and Deta struggled to keep up. Deta avoided the villagers’ questions about why Heidi was leaving. As they saw Heidi pulling Deta along, she said, “I can’t stop. Can’t you see the child is in a hurry? We still have a long way



*Dete runs after Heidi*

to go.”

The villagers whispered among themselves. They wondered if Heidi was going with Dete willingly. Or maybe she was running away from her grandfather. They were surprised to see her looking so healthy and rosy. But soon, Heidi and Dete were far from the village.

From then on, Grandfather looked angrier whenever he came down to the village. He was only there to sell his goat cheese and buy food. People were scared of him and told their children to stay away. Many people thought it was good that Heidi had left him. They had seen her rushing away and thought she was happy to go.

Only Grandmother still supported him faithfully. Whenever someone came near her, she would talk about how well the old man had taken care of Heidi. She would also tell them how he had fixed up her little house. People in the village only half believed these stories because Grandmother was very old and frail. She started feeling sad again every day. “All the happiness left when Heidi did,” the old woman would say every day. “The days are so long and dull, and I don’t feel happy anymore. I wish I could hear Heidi’s voice one more time before I pass away.”